

PLANESWALKER'S GUIDE TO THEROS

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This is the first of three Planeswalker's Guides for the world of Theros and the eponymous first expansion set there.

The Plane of Theros

The caprice of the gods, the destined hero, the great journey, the untamed wilds beyond the city walls, the raging sea, the birth of civilization, temples and burnt offerings, hoplites and phalanxes, hydras, gorgons, minotaurs, sacred and profane rites and rituals, great thinkers, enlightened despots, revels in the woods, the power of belief-Theros is a plane filled with divine magic and monstrous danger, where heroes are born and where legends are made.



Art by Zack Stella

The Land of Nyx

When mortals sleep and dream on Theros, they are said to "visit Nyx," the proverbial land of night and the home of the gods. Therefore, dreams are seen as gifts from the gods. When the gods appear to mortals, each is "infused" with Nyx itself. Where the god's features or form would be shadowed, instead the night sky is visible, as though the gods occupy the daylit world and the nighttime world at once.



Art by Sam Burley

Enchantments: Magic of the Gods

The gods themselves are *living enchantments*. For this reason, all enchantments are thought to be gifts from the gods—a unique form of magic enabled by divinities.

Additionally, when other creatures such as nymphs demonstrate the "infusion" of night sky that all the gods have in common, it's taken as evidence that the nymphs are servants of the gods,

native to Nyx, and only visiting the sunlit, mortal world at the gods' behest.



Art by Volkan Baga

The Gods of Theros

Countless generations of stories and faiths have led to a pantheon of gods that oversees the most important aspects of Theran life.

Heliod, God of the Sun



Art by Jamie Jones

Domains: Heliod represents law, justice, retribution, and the bonds of kinship. Heliod presides over matters of family honor, questions of morality and virtue, speeches, marriages, acts of protective bravery, dawn meals, and self-sacrifice. Heliod's name is often part of legal proceedings, and sacrifices to him are made in times when the greatest aid-or the strictest justice-is needed.

Signature item: Heliod wields Khrusor, the Sun Spear, a weapon blessed with his power that can be pitched down from the heavens to any point on Theros. Obscure legends say that another major polis once existed, a coastal city known as Arixmethes, that Heliod smote with Khrusor and cast into the sea.



Art by Yeong-Hao Han

Personality: Heliod radiates with pride and self-assurance. His presence fills the sky with light, blocking mortal access to the dark, starry view of Nyx, and in person he has the same overwhelming aura of awe and brilliance. He is convivial and gregarious, making friends and forming bonds easily, and he sees himself as the ally to all. But others know that Heliod can be fickle in his loyalty. Heliod's greatest ally today might be the target of his retribution tomorrow.



Art by Nils Hamm

Worship: Heliod is the sun god, literally bringing the light of day to the world, so almost everyone on Theros pays at least tokenistic acknowledgment to him. Some families have a custom of winking in the direction of the dawn's light first thing in the morning, a gesture of respect to the sun god's luminous eye. Heliod's devoted worshippers are mainly humans and Laggona Band centaurs, who celebrate Heliod on the first clear-skied morning of every month. Temples to Heliod often feature stairs up to a rooftop courtyard, enabling sun worship. The largest holiday aligned with Heliod is the summer solstice, celebrated with three days of ceremonious feasting, weddings, and oaths of loyalty.

Thassa, God of the Sea



Art by Jason Chan

Domains: Thassa is the god of the sea and also presides over aquatic creatures and the secrets of the briny deep. But she is also the god of ancient knowledge, murmurs, gradual change, introspection, vast distances, long voyages, and far-ranging searches. Thassa might also be described as the god of patterns, such as those of tides, currents, ripples in water, and even the passage of time.

Signature item: Thassa wields Dekella, a two-pronged spear. Wielding Dekella allows her to control the tides and stir the seas into whirlpools. Legend has it that a mortal sailor once stole Dekella and used it to destroy an enemy fleet, and that Thassa punished the mortal by turning his entire family into eels.



Art by Yeong-Hao Han

Personality: Thassa is the god who is least likely to be satisfied with the status quo, but also the least likely to rush to change. She is constantly striving to resculpt the land, changing coastlines and upending institutions for the purpose of slow, eventual, unfolding change.

When she speaks, she often uses the future tense, always referring to what tomorrow will bring, forever uninterested with the reality of today. Thassa is slow to anger but implacable once roused. Her anger can grow like a rumbling, cresting, unstoppable wave, taking out whole villages with its fury-then subside with the tide, dragging the evidence of her wrath calmly out to sea.



Art by Clint Cearley

Worship: Tritons and the humans of Meletis comprise most of Thassa's worshippers, as well as all who venture out to sea, whether for exploration, commerce, or war. Although tritons exalt her above all other gods, she shows no favoritism toward them, seeming equally impassive to all mortals. She is worshipped with offerings of fish and salt by the poor, offerings of pearls and nacre by the rich, and with murmured prayers and quiet contemplation by all.

Erebos, God of the Underworld



Art by Peter Mohrbacher

When the sun first shone on Heliod, god of the sun, the first shadow was cast. When Heliod saw it, he feared and banished it, sending it beyond the so-called Rivers That Ring the World, the five rivers that form a boundary between Theros and its Underworld. That shadow became Erebos, the god of death. In time, Erebos accepted his role, knowing that although Heliod had banished him, he would always stand behind the sun god.

Domains: Erebos rules over death and the Underworld, but these aren't his only duties. Because of his own origins, he is also the god of misfortune, ill fate, begrudging acceptance, envy, and bitterness. And because he is lord of the Underworld, where gold is common and valueless, he is also the god of wealth.

Although it might seem as though Erebos is connected to Nyx more closely than the other gods, this isn't the case. Erebos's realm lacks both the sun and the night.

Signature item: Erebus wields Mastix, a golden-handled whip with an impossibly long lash, like a thin shadow that stretches on forever. The whip is a means of inflicting pain when he must, but its more frequent function is as a snare to pull the reluctant dead into-or back into-his realm.



Art by Yeong-Hao Han

Personality: Erebus is an effective warden and lord of the Underworld realm. He is not without compassion, but his compassion is limited to feeling on behalf of others what he himself feels, and his acceptance of his fate means that his lieges, the dead, must accept theirs. He idly envies the sunlit world of the living, but only in a daydream-like way. He knows that all mortal souls will eventually join him, which affords him a kind of satisfaction and certainty. When others suffer, it brings Erebus peace, but not glee, because the alienation and banishment of others enables them to identify with his own.



Art by Dan Scott

Worship: The god of the underworld is worshipped by three distinct sets of mortal beings: those who exalt death, those who desire wealth, and those who pray for acceptance of their fates. The first group is the smallest but most dangerous; they seek to bring about a confrontation between Helioid and his shadow. The second group is largest. Because the dead leave their earthly wealth behind, Erebus has become associated with that wealth, as well as with the abundance of (to him, pretty but valueless) gold in his realm. The final group is closest to Erebus's heart—those who have been cast out and who seek peace with their fate.

Purphoros, God of the Forge



Art by Eric Deschamps

Domains: Purphoros is the god of the forge, the restless earth, and fire. He rules the raw creative force of heat and energy that fills the souls of sentient beings. His energy emerges as chaos, something to be harnessed and shaped by labor and passion. For this reason, Purphoros is also the god of artisans, of obsession, and of the cycle of creation and destruction.

Signature item: Purphoros wields Akmon, a large hammer whose head slightly resembles an anvil. A blow from Akmon can render the earth molten, and when it strikes metal, each spark becomes a new enchantment, some of which even take on life.



Art by Yeong-Hao Han

Personality: To sit in the presence of Purphoros is to be inspired. He forges the most ornate and delicate items only to dash them into flame and start again. He is reasonable yet ultimately follows no rules save his own creative and destructive impulses. Sometimes, this can mean covering a whole area with lava to make way for something new. His main flaw is that of frustration, of feeling limited and constrained. He is forever pushing against the barriers of mortal imagination, sensing that there is much more to express. This can cause him to plummet into despondency and then lash out at the world with raw destruction.



Art by Mathias Kollros

Worship: Followers of Purphoros, the god of the forge, brought the secret of bronze to Theros, leading to stronger objects and armaments than any created previously. And the most sanctified shamans of Purphoros also possess small quantities of a new metal said to have come from Purphoros's forge: iron. But it's not only smiths who worship him. Artists, human and satyr especially, seek his aid, ascending to altars on volcanic slopes to breathe deeply of the creative vapors. Warriors give him homage when lighting a bonfire. Potters inscribe their works with markings meant to honor him.

Nylea, God of the Hunt



Art by Chris Rahn

Domains: Nylea is the god of the hunt, the seasons, and the forest. Because of her reign over the hunt, she is also associated with predation and hunger. And because of her rule of the seasons, she is also the god of metamorphosis and rebirth. Nylea receives strength and peace from sleeping inside the chrysalis at the center of her grove.

Signature item: Nylea is Theros's finest archer, and she wields a shortbow called Ephixis. Her companion, the nymph Theophila, conjures illusions for target practice, such as fireflies or miniscule silk worms. Nylea has no qualms with predation, but she loathes hunting for sport. She personally kills poachers in the Nistos Forest who have not asked for her blessing to hunt her animals.



Art by Yeong-Hao Han

Personality: Nylea is usually aloof and thoughtful, but with her companions she is playful and joyful. She has a feral, animalistic side and shoulders the responsibility of keeping the forest a haven for animals, preventing the spread of humans into her domain, and letting the natural world have free rein. Nylea is quick to anger and vengeance if something threatens her realm. The seasons change at her whim, and she delays the change if angered. She is allied with Purphoros, and permits him to unleash fires on the forest when it is in need of cleansing or when humans are encroaching too far into the wilds.

Nylea has a tumultuous relationship with Karametra, the god of the hearth. Karametra is infuriated by Nylea's interference in the seasons. In turn, Nylea is disgusted by agriculture, which she sees as an aberration from the natural cycle of the world.



Art by Mathias Kollros

Worship: Nylea doesn't have temples built in her honor. She dislikes the construction of temples and cities in general. Nymphs of all kinds pay homage to her, as do sentient humanoid creatures such as satyrs, centaurs, and many citizens of Setessa. Her holy sites often consist of a tree surrounded by a cloud of butterflies. When one of these trees is spotted, people say she is near. Her human followers tend to be loners, outcasts, and those who choose to live in the wilds. Some city dwellers will come into the forest to honor her, especially to pray that the seasons will change in a timely manner. Nylea hates sacrifices and is notoriously hard to please.

Depending on their offerings, worshippers could as easily anger her as win her blessing. She enjoys seeing acts of kindness and protection of creatures both domesticated and wild.



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THE POLEIS

The humans of Theros embody the spirit of carving out a place for civilization from the wilds. Although other, smaller settlements exist, the majority of humans are associated with one of Theros's three major poleis: Meletis, Akros, and Setessa.

Meletis



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Meletis is the polis of learning, magic, and progress. It is a city-state of progressive thinkers, pious thaumaturges, and wise oracles. Meletis was born from the defeat of tyranny, and to this day it retains a spirit of the triumph of free thought over brutish force. Meletians pride themselves on their great temples to the gods, their thaumaturgical academy, their great works of architecture, and for their Reverent Army.



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Field and river, city and sea. Meletis sits on the coast, surrounded by rivers and vast, stepped grasslands. Fields of a cultivated type of barley called sitra provide sustenance to Meletians and their animals. Branches of the River Kheir splay out across the landscape, bringing fresh water and trade from distant villages.



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Hub of civilization. The great temples of Meletis are testaments to the achievements of civilized humanity. Signs of architectural and academic achievement are everywhere. Even the streets of Meletis are formed of bricks of interlocking geometric shapes, demonstrating mathematical and mystical principles. The wildlands of Theros feel distant, almost mythical, from inside the city's bounds. Meletis does suffer attacks from sirens, tritons, and larger monsters, but many citizens of Meletis have never seen in person any monster bigger or more exotic than a centaur.



Concept Art by Steve Prescott

Devotion to the gods. Meletians are very concerned with the actions of the gods. Gods are regularly part of their language. Here are some phrases common in Meletis that incorporate the gods:

"By Heliod's bright spear." Expresses surprise or wonder.

"From the gods' voice to my ears" (or simply *"gods' voice"*). Used to emphasize that what the speaker says is true-i.e., that the speaker has been told this by the gods themselves.

"By the red eye of Mogis." A mild profanity, often used in reaction to tragedy or violent death.

"With Erebos" or *"At Erebos's side."* Another way of saying "deceased" or "in the Underworld."

Locations

Temples. Almost every street of Meletis bears a temple, from simple, one-room neighborhood shrines to six-story temples held up by phalanxes of marble columns. Every god has a temple in Meletis, and many temples are devoted to multiple gods. Artisans continually improve the temples in Meletis, swapping out broken marble or crumbling sculptures with fresh materials, and painting over grand friezes with even grander ones.

The Dakra, isles of enchantment. Meletis sits on the Siren Sea, surrounded by a host of small islands called the Dakra. The Dakra are said to have been created when Thassa, god of the sea, felt sorrow that Korinna, ancient queen of the tritons, had been killed by a human's harpoon. Thassa's tears fell onto the sea in the form of an archipelago of misty isles. The Dakra have rarely been settled by humans, as they harbor strange nymphs and fierce monsters, and are enchanted with the magic of the gods.



Art by Raoul Vitale

Roles and Personalities

Thaumaturges, the mage-elite. Weaving magic is a time-honored tradition in Meletis; magic is seen as one of the greatest arts an artisan can master. The most accomplished mages are known as thaumaturges ("wonder workers"). Many Meletian mages received training at the Dekatia, including many thaumaturges, but one is not truly considered a thaumaturge until one has received a reward or other positive omen from the gods. For example, a mage might be considered a thaumaturge when Heliod, god of the sun, grants her a spear of sunlight, or when she is granted a wild creative vision by Keranos, god of storms.

The stonewise. Meletis is a polis of industry and building. Stonewise thaumaturges specialize in magic that erects and restores buildings and other such edifices. Stonewise mages are crucial to the Reverent Army when creating inland military outposts.

Formalists. The Æther is of particular interest to Meletian scholars, and many study its use in magic. Some believe that the Æther is the realm of abstract entities, such as numbers, concepts, and theories. Some formalists study magics that allow them to cause objects to disappear from physical reality. They say they are "perfecting" real, necessarily flawed, concrete objects by transferring them to the realm of perfect, abstract entities.

Philosophers and the Twelve. Meletis is world renowned as the center of philosophical thought. Philosophers have special status here; they are often attended by servants so that they might spend more of their time debating, thinking, and teaching. The Twelve, a council of philosophers, serves as the ruling body of Meletis. The Twelve are currently headed by Perisophia.



Art by James Ryman

The Reverent Army. Meletis is defended by the Reverent Army, religiously trained soldiers who fight monsters and exalt the gods. The Meletian Reverents are not as fierce as Akroans nor as sturdy as Setessans, but they are clever and resourceful, and they believe their superior piety for Theros's pantheon leads them to more success in battle.



Art by Willian Murai

The Battlewise. Meletian soldiers are trained to manipulate the battlefield primarily through tactics rather than through physical strength. Their hoplites use clever ruses, unusual or rapidly changing troop formations, and even outright deception to score victories.



Art by [Lucas Graciano](#)

Spell-trained. It's said that every Meletian soldier knows at least one spell. That may be an exaggeration that Meletians allow to circulate, but it is true that many Meletian hoplites could be considered low-level taskmages. Spells of healing, endurance augmentation, and battlefield trickery are often taught during soldier training.

Nonhumans in Meletis. Tritons can survive for only a short while on land, yet a few tritons make their home in the coastal city of Meletis. Some serve as lookouts and tower-keepers who watch the shores, warning Meletians of attacks by krakens,

archons, or other monsters. Others attend the baths or even instruct students as adjunct philosophers at the Dekatia.

Many Pheres Band centaurs are hostile to Meletians, but Meletis officially maintains a fragile peace with the Laggona Band. Some smaller centaur tribes have established a profitable trade with the polis. Meletian officials even designate two holidays during the year, making allowances for the overlap with certain centaur celebrations. In accordance with the peace, Meletian outposts generally allow smaller centaur bands to move across their surveyed lands, but some Meletian soldiers aren't happy about it.



Art by Min Yum

Medomai, the wandering oracle. The wise and ancient sphinx Medomai is not a consistent resident of Meletis. Instead, he appears a few times a year during moments of historical import, such as religious ceremonies, coronations, and the onset of wars. Medomai has been part of Meletis's history for many decades, seeming to possess cryptic knowledge of future events. His

arrival is not necessarily seen as a good omen, as his predictions can be dire.



Art by David Palumbo

Perisophia, the great philosopher. The most learned living philosopher of Meletis is Perisophia, whose skills at logic, rhetoric, and mind magic are so formidable that she is the match for any debater in any forum. Perisophia currently rules as the most senior member of the Twelve.

Hypatia of the Winged Horse. Hypatia was trained as a grange-mage in a Meletian temple to Karametra but found that her calling was on the field of battle. She took up the sword and shield of the Meletian army and showed great promise fighting off threats to the city.

During one battle, she was wounded on a high plateau overlooking Meletis. She saw a pegasus herd flying overhead and said a silent prayer. A pegasus flew down and allowed her to

climb onto its back, saving her life. The two of them became inseparable.



Art by Cynthia Sheppard

Thrasios, the triton hero. Only a handful of tritons live among the humans of Meletis. The most famous is Thrasios, an accomplished warrior who believes he bears the divine sanction of Thassa, god of the sea. Meletians saved Thrasios's family from a pack of marauding minotaurs, so he now fights for the honor of Meletis. His prowess in battle is said to be miraculous; no blow ever seems to land on him.

HISTORY

Agnomakhos, the Archon Tyrant. Meletians know that the area that is now their city-state was once ruled by an archon-a hooded warlord who rode a great flying beast-called Agnomakhos. Agnomakhos ruled with an iron fist for centuries, apparently immortal, outliving the generations of leonin that he

used as his soldiers and personal guard. Agnomakhos aggressively expanded his empire during his reign, spreading it as far as the forests to the north and the mountains to the east, imposing merciless order over the wilds wherever he went.

The legend goes that the god Ephara granted magic to the humans to help them overthrow Agnomakhos, cast out the leonin, and free Meletis from tyranny. The humans who were victorious over Agnomakhos founded the enlightened polis of Meletis from the wreckage of Agnomakhos's empire. To this day, the leonin remain detached from Meletis and uninterested in trade or dialogue.

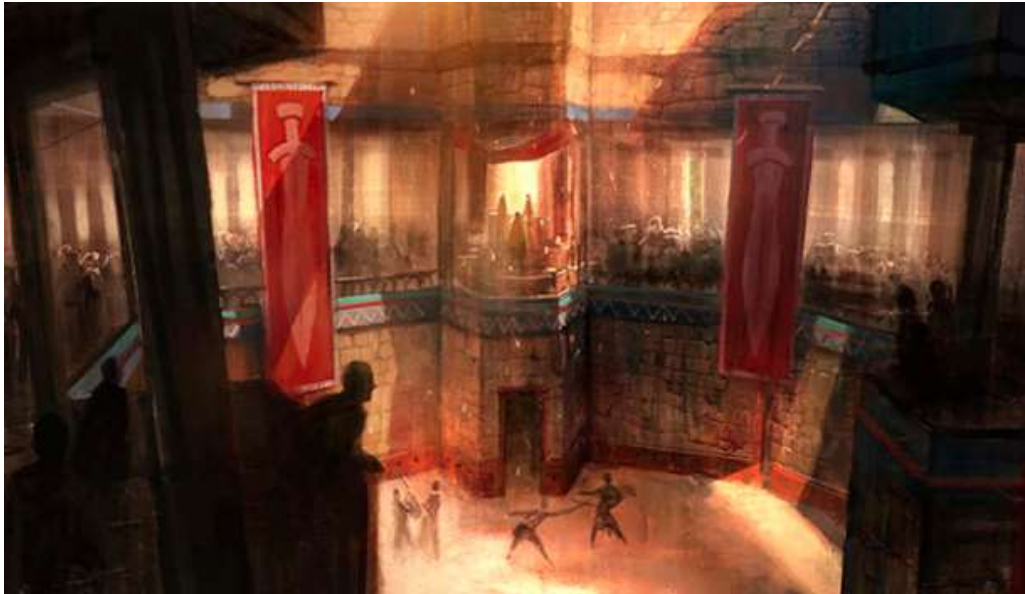
Akros



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

The mountain realms that surround the mighty polis of Akros serve as shield between its holdings and the rest of Theros. The Akroans are half-mythical even within their own time. They are known to be the most feared warriors of Theros. They have lived and died by the spear in the name of countless kings, hardening their armies generation after generation by fostering a culture

that revolves around perfecting the body and the mind for combat.



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Locations

The Kolophon. The central fortress and seat of Akroan power is the Kolophon, a huge, many-tiered structure perched on a cliff. Within its thick stone walls the Akroan people worship, train, and conduct their lives. At the innermost part of the Kolophon rests the hall of the Akroan king. Here, scouts and couriers give reports from outposts that stretch to the furthest reaches of the Akroan territories.



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Outposts. Scattered throughout Akros are several outposts- staging grounds for Stratians to venture out and seek plunder or patrol for monsters and invaders.

- **One-Eyed Pass.** This outpost has been carefully chosen by the Stratians for a particular reason: the abundance of cyclopes. They funnel their enemies into the pass, using the cyclopes who aggressively defend their territory as a gauntlet of certain death.



Art by Chase Stone

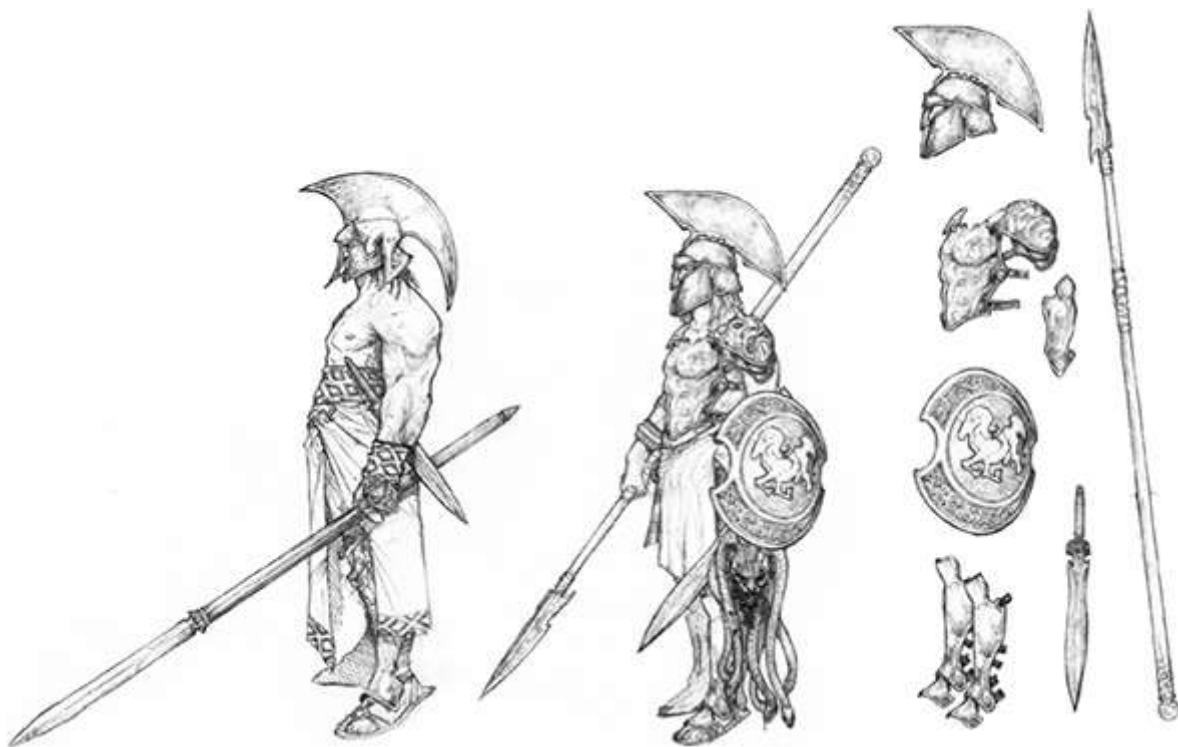
- **Pharagax Bridge.** The Stratians defend this huge stone bridge with all their might against any who would enter Akros without the king's permission. Some claim that the massive chasm it spans leads to the Underworld, and that foul creatures emerge from its depths.
- **The Titan's Stairs.** This is a natural access through the granite cliffs that protect Akros. Stratians have guarded this strange formation for centuries and have used it as a staging ground for invading the lowlands.

Temples. There are a few temples in Akros dedicated to the major gods-mainly Purphoros and Iroas-but due to the Stratian duties of many Akroans, the major temples are located afield, in mountainous places.

Phoberos. Phoberos is the badlands of the Akroan realm. It is the line of demarcation between relative safety and certain peril. Encampments of Stratians are always stationed here on the border between the human realm and those beyond. They're relieved every month or so by a fresh cadre of troops, who inevitably hear terrifying stories of marauding leonin, flesh-eating minotaurs, and firebreathing dragons. The borderland between Phoberos and Akros is long and rugged, and the Stratians are kept in wandering groups, patrolling the whole of the Akroan frontier.

Roles and Personalities

Stratians. Although the center of Akroan culture is located within the great walls of the Kolophon, the main body of the population consists of wandering bands of warriors that make up the Akroan army: the Stratians. These warrior bands are entirely self sufficient, relying on hunting and plunder to feed their numbers and to train the young soldiers in the field. The Stratians are tasked with scouring the countryside for monsters that have strayed from their domains seeking to attack merchants and traders who travel the roads between poleis.



Concept Art by Richard Whitters

- **Alamon (wanderers).** These are the forces that are always on the move about the borders of the kingdom of Akros. They are tough and rugged warriors armed for speed, so they can move and strike without warning. They are the forces who find new domains for conquering.



Art by John Severin Brassell

- **Lukos (wolves).** These are the elite of the Akroan forces called in after the Alamon have spotted a target and have begun attacking it in their guerrilla style of assault. The Lukos march in and take over the village, capturing slaves to haul plunder back to the Kolophon.



Art by Johann Bodin

- **Oromai (watchers).** These are the forces that never stray far from the Kolophon, protecting the fortress from invaders. The Oromai also keep the large population of serfs in check while the main part of the Akroan army is away for long periods of time.

Anax and Cymede. The current king of Akros is a fierce warrior named Anax. The current-equally fierce-queen is Cymede.



Anax and Cymede | Art by Willian Murai

Anax is a burly man in his late 40s, once a follower of Iroas. In his later years he has turned to Purphoros as he steers his people through the creation of a small empire. This shift is reflected in the trend in art now seen from Akroan artisans. Swords and armor are now decorated. Pottery, clothing, wall paintings, and weaving show ancient Akroan patterns and symbolism handed down for generations. To his people, Anax is a great leader to be followed without question. To other poleis, he is known as a skilled tactician and heartless killer.

Cymede worships Keranos primarily. She is a skilled warrior but a more powerful seer. Having herself been struck by lightning and given a glimpse of the future, Cymede is seen by some as being partly responsible for her husband's effectiveness as king. Cymede is beginning to become aware of the power of godly creatures such as nymphs. She has seen abstract glimpses of their power and feels the gods are bestowing gifts on the faithful. Because of this, the cult of Keranos is gaining a foothold in the Kolophon. Cymede has even had a special temple built on a distant mountain summit where the storms are particularly severe. During the storm season, she visits there, meditating on a silver platform.

Flamespeakers. These shamans of Purphoros worship strange eidolons said to inhabit the volcanoes and cracks in the great mountains of Akros. The Flamespeakers still have the ear and belief of many modern Akroans, and some make the pilgrimage far up into the mountains to be blessed by Flamespeakers or to receive prophecy from them.



Art by Maciej Kuciara

Androphages. During training, every Stratian is warned about the threat of Mogis, because it is during battle when the god can slip into the hearts of warriors, making them crave ever more blood and pain. All Akroans know how Mogis can take a small flame of revenge and grow it into an inferno of madness. Those who are overcome by such desires flee the polis to find enclaves of those who worship Mogis. Not all who worship the twisted god are cannibals, but all crave rage and bloodlust-and some do crave human flesh as the minotaurs do.

The Iroan Games.



Art by Jason Felix

Because of their warrior culture and discipline, the god Iroas favors the Akroans. The Iroan games are held every year in the withering heat of the summer to weed out pretenders and to allow only the most hardy of athletes to prevail. The central podium where athletes receive awards is also the main temple of Iroas.

- **Arissa.** A hero of recent Iroan games is a woman called Arissa. She comes from a little-known village and defeated all comers in javelin at the games, but that is not what gained her immortality. In a fit of jealousy, Mogis sent a black, bat-like creature to snatch the young son of an Akroan hero during the ceremony following the games. As it flew into the air with the child, Arissa threw her javelin farther than humanly possible, skewering the bat-thing; she caught the babe and returned it safe and sound.
- **Lanathos.** The Akroan wrestler Lanathos, after defeating all combatants in the arena, took on a wild Akroan bull for a true challenge, pinning the beast after a day-long struggle.



Art by Jason Chan

- **Nymosyne.** A warrior from Setessa, Nymosyne was renowned for her prowess at pankration (a hybrid of boxing and wrestling). Legend has it that in the middle of a match, a cyclops raided the grounds of the games, attacking spectators and combatants. Nymosyne jumped out of the arena and, after a brief clash, snapped the monster's neck.

Setessa



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Geography

From a bird's-eye view, Setessa's layout resembles the rings of a tree, which radiate outward from the Temple of Karametra at its heart. Swaths of forest alternate with family dwellings and other civic structures. Setessa encompasses a sprawling area on the border between the Nistos Forest and the open chaparral. Roads are winding and narrow and usually not wide enough to accommodate a cart. Rope bridges provide easy foot travel through the wild spaces.

To the south, Setessa is bordered by a high ridge whose inhabitants have carved it into "shelves" for terrace farming and orchards, as well as digging warren-like dwellings inside the ridge itself. These defensible locations are used for protection when the city is attacked. Secret tunnels lead out into the forest.

Setessa's outermost ring is a dense circle of trees and vegetation that functions as a natural wall against outsiders. The trees have platforms for archers and the wall is constantly guarded. Karametra's warrior-priests monitor who enters and exits the

city. Although the people of Setessa value community and treat each other as family, outsiders are not readily welcomed.



Concept Art by Adam Paquette

Population and Social Order

Setessa is populated mainly by women and children. There is no marriage and property is held communally. Ancestors are traced matrilineally. For the inhabitants of Setessa, the welfare of children is paramount. Karametra, the polis's patron, is the god of orphans, and abandoned children are brought from outside to be raised by the polis. The children of Setessa are called *arkulli* ("little bears"-singular *arkullos*), and are held in the highest esteem by the entire community. Children are welcomed everywhere, from the temple to the training grounds.



Concept Art by Steve Prescott



Concept Art by Steve Prescott

There are men in Setessa, but most live near the Amatrophon, a menagerie at the edge of the polis. At a young age, men are encouraged to "peregrinate," a practice of wandering the world and seeking a home beyond that of their mothers. It is believed that women become heroes through martial training, while men become heroes by finding their own way in the world.

Kelema Veil and the Nexuses

Setessa has a nexus honoring each of Nylea's seasons and the accompanying Karametran planting rituals. There are no temples to other gods in Setessa, but offerings to any god may be placed at these holy sites. Under each nexus is a starfield—a vision of Nyx.

As conduits to the various gods, the nexuses are a source of enchantment magic in this region. This phenomenon is called the Kelema Veil. In Setessa, oracles can decipher the Kelema Veil. It has been described as a misty starfield that flows across the land. Inside the starfield are images that resemble constellations. These tell stories of the gods and can be used to predict the future.



Art by Adam Paquette

Spring Nexus. The Spring Nexus is in a lush garden behind Karametra's temple. Its form is that of an arch made of vines and flowers that never fade. The Spring Nexus is the source of the magic of abundance, summoning, and healing. Although they have a tumultuous relationship, Karametra speaks of Nylea as her sister, and encourages people to leave offerings for her here.

Summer Nexus. The Summer Nexus is in an ancient olive grove near the Bassara Tower. Dark green leaves form a canopy over the grove, and it is a favorite resting spot for the many animals who wander freely through the polis. Summer is seen a time of

strength, and the Summer Nexus is a source of increased power. Nylea is worshipped here, as is Iroas before the Iroan Games.



Art by Wesley Burt

Autumn Nexus. The Autumn Nexus is in a golden-apple orchard along the Southern Ridge. A natural basalt arch leads into a narrow cave where a fire is kept burning at all times. The people of Setessa believe that it is Purphoros's fire that warms the earth enough for the autumn harvest, so people give offerings in hopes of an autumn bounty. The Setessan warriors pay homage here to the Twins of War, Iroas and Mogis; they see honor and fear as equal parts in victory.



Art by Matt Stewart

Winter Nexus. Winter is seen as a time of sleep and death. The Winter Nexus is at the far edge of Setessa in an old lion's den believed to predate the founding of Setessa. The ancient den is in a small rocky cave below a burial mound. The cave is said to lead down to the Underworld itself, and the smell of blood and decay hangs in the air. Here, people make offerings to Pharika and to Erebos in hopes of sparing themselves grief or pain in old age, or in remembrance of someone who now walks in the Underworld.

Watchtowers and Forts



Art by Greg Staples

There are four watchtowers in Setessa. Each is named for an animal, and each has a regiment of Setessan warriors attached to it.

Leina Tower (lion). This limestone tower stands near the Temple to Karametra at the heart of Setessa and houses the polis's protectors. They fight with double-edged axes and provide most of the martial training for the arkulli. Their leader is Anthousa, who also leads Karametra's Council of Warriors. She is considered the god's closest advisor and *de facto* ruler of the city when the god is not present, which is much of the time.



Art by Raymond Swanland

Hyrax Tower (falcon). This wooden tower stands on the ridge along Setessa's southern border. It is occupied by falconers and scouts. Their leader is Phaedra, a former orphan from Meletis raised in Setessa. She is only nineteen years old, but her skills in battle earned her a place of leadership.

Bassara Tower (fox). The regiment stationed in this tower protects the Nistos Forest and watches for interlopers who enter without Nylea's permission. Bassara warriors are welcomed by Nylea and spend extended periods of time living among the ancient trees. During their training, they focus on archery and guerrilla warfare. Their leader is Niketa, a woman in her fifties who now spends most of her time in Setessa. She supervises archery training for the arkulli.



Art by Ryan Barger

Ophis Tower (serpent). This tower is hidden in a wild space near the temple to Karametra. It serves as a base for wandering warriors and spies who travel incognito to gather information for the Council of Warriors. They search out routes for "peregrinations," including sympathetic households who will mentor young men at the beginning of their journeys. Ophis warriors also seek lost and abandoned children and bring them back to Setessa. Their leader is Kallias, who was sold into slavery as a child. She lost an eye and several fingers before she was rescued by the Ophis and brought to Setessa.



Art by Steve Prescott

Notable Places

Abora Market. The Abora Market is a giant, open-air market just inside the main gate of Setessa. Outsiders are allowed to use the market on certain days but are prohibited from roaming the polis at large. For Setessans, the market is open every day, year round.

Currency is not common, although foreign sellers sometimes accept coin. For Setessans, all commerce is done in trade. Fresh fruit, vegetables, baked goods, fish, meat, nuts, seeds, and spices are all plentiful. There is a permanent "raptor hall," where falcons and other trained raptors are sold to merchants from other cities. Trained Setessian raptors are considered the best in Theros.



Concept Art by [Adam Paquette](#)

Amatrophon. The Amatrophon is a safe haven and training ground for a diverse range of animals. These creatures occupy an honored place in society. The Amatrophon encompasses a large region of forest and grassland at the edge of Setessa. There are

extensive stables for horses and combat training grounds for warriors and animals alike. Karametra values animals as natural protectors. Pegasuses, wolves, and even lions are all trained to accompany warriors in combat. They also wander freely through the polis, serving as free-ranging guards. Men who remain in Setessa take care of the animals and help train horses, falcons, and other animals.

Anthousa and the Colossus. After a storm shook Setessa, taking down centuries-old trees, Karametra chastised Keranos for his selfishness. Furious at her impudence, Keranos sent a storm of truly epic proportions to destroy the crops, snap the branches from the young trees, and force the people to huddle indoors.

Young Anthousa had been hunting and was caught in the deluge. Knowing she was Karametra's favorite, Keranos sent a bolt of lightning down from Nyx. It struck the grave of a titan, buried for countless centuries under the earth. The ground rose before Anthousa, uprooting trees as frightened birds fled into the stormy sky. An earth-titan, easily thirty feet tall, rose from his primordial resting place. Grabbing the trunk of a broken tree, he swung wildly at the young warrior. Anthousa narrowly escaped, and the titan gave chase. Nylea saw the scars on the face of her forest and raised vines to clutch at the titan's legs. Turning back, Anthousa saw the titan stumble. Quick as a deer, she used the vines to scale up to his shoulder as he struggled to get free. Anthousa sought the soft flesh just below the titan's ear.

Calling out to Karametra, she drove her dagger deep into the flesh. Hearing her daughter's plea, Karametra enchanted Anthousa, giving her the preternatural strength needed to cleave the titan's head from his body. The severed head fell to the ground, where it sunk halfway into storm-soaked earth. There the skull lies to this day, the home of foxes that shelter in the great cave of his mouth.



Art by David Palumbo



This is the third of three Planeswalker's Guides for the world of Theros and the eponymous first expansion set there.

NONHUMAN CREATURES



Hundred-Handed One | Art by Brad Rigney

Humanity isn't the only sentient race of Theros. Across the plane, several other humanoid races live under the eyes of the gods: tritons and civilized centaurs along the coasts, wilder centaurs and satyrs in the chaparral, and leonin and minotaurs in the rocky badlands. Undead escapees from the Underworld, known as the Returned, settle in the forgotten corners of the plane.

Leonin



Concept Art by Peter Mohrbacher

Beyond the borders of Akros lie the leonin dens. They are scattered throughout the rocky scrublands and low mountains, away from the human poleis of Theros. The leonin keep to themselves, interacting with other races only when they must: for trade and, occasionally, for raids.

Renunciation of Human Gods

There was a time, centuries ago, when the leonin worshipped the same gods as their human counterparts, but after the era of the tyrannical archon Agnomakhos, the leonin rejected all human ways in a bitter backlash that has defined their role on Theros ever since. Most revere the hunt and the pride, but according to chronicler Lanathos, some leonin still make offerings to Heliod and Nylea.



Art by Peter Mohrbacher

Locations

Oreskos. This central domain of the leonin lies in a rocky river valley in a remote region of Theros. Here, one can see the old influence from when the leonin were ruled from Meletis. In Oreskos, a smattering of human culture remains from their time under the oppression of Agnomakhos, but the leonin are slowly reverting back to their original nature, abandoning the ideology and culture that have been imposed on them throughout their history.



Art by Raymond Swanland

Tethmos. This is the primary leonin den, high in the mountains. Leonin in Tethmos train endlessly and are constantly ready. They prepare both for skirmishes against the Akroans intruding in their lands as well as from a culturally ingrained fear that the Meletians will attempt to enslave them again.

Roles and Personalities

Brimaz, the leonin king. The leonin king is both a warrior and a spiritual leader for his people. Each king is considered the manifestation of nature's animus on earth. Brimaz is a capable warrior and an inspiring leader but has private doubts about the isolationism of leonin culture.

Lanathos. Lanathos is a Meletian chronicler who has traveled all over Theros. He is the only human known to have been allowed to document the leonin and their ways, because he tells a sympathetic story about their origins: that Meletis is actually their

ancestral homeland and that they may one day hope to reclaim it.



Art by Kev Walker

Tritons



Art by Greg Staples

Tritons are a race of sea-dwellers who can plague sailors and coastal poleis such as Meletis. Tritons are partially amphibious—they can breathe air for several days at a time but must spend time in water to keep their gills soft. Tritons worship the sea god Thassa above all others and work to do her bidding.

The Hand of Thassa

While tritons pay respect to many gods, they are devoted to Thassa, god of the sea. Tritons see Thassa as the primary god of the pantheon of Theros, believing she will bring their race to ascendancy over beasts of the sea and the human-dominated poleis of the land. Tritons often act at Thassa's direct command, drowning boats in magically conjured whirlpools or creating great monuments on the Dakra Isles.

Triton priests lead ceremonies honoring Thassa, often involving offerings at towering shell-altars both under the sea and on land. Some triton worshippers create magical sculptures out of saltwater that tower up out of the ocean, then crash down into the waves again.



Thassa, God of the Sea | Art by [Jason Chan](#)

The Returned



Art by Seb McKinnon

When sentient, mortal beings die on Theros, they pass into its Underworld. They dwell in this eternally gray realm without sun or night under the watch of Erebos, god of the Underworld. But over the centuries, many denizens of the Underworld have escaped and returned to the sunlit realm of the living. They are called the Noston (from *nostos*, "to return home"), or the Returned.



Art by Mark Zug

Loss of identity. To leave the Underworld, beings must give up their identity and their very faces, each of which becomes an unsettling surface with eyeholes and a mouth. This doesn't mean that the Returned have no personality and no memory of anything, however. One's name and past are forgotten, but skills and personality are retained. That is, the events and relationships of the mortal's life are lost, but the results of those events are intact (such as speech or the ability to play music). In addition, the Returned lose the ability to form the long-term memories on which relationships are based—they are unable to "build a new life," as it were.



Concept Art by Peter Mohrbacher

Sentient, sapient zombies. The Returned are undead in the most actual sense. When they return to the living realm, they don't return to life. They need water and air but not food. The Returned form communities, experience fleeting emotions, and follow daily routines, but their existence is a shadow play, because without an identity or an ability to nurture long-term relationships, the elements of their "lives" have no weight or substance.

They aren't just thinking, speaking zombies but also feeling ones. Although their lack of identity prevents long-term memory formation, they do feel emotions based on their experiences. That in turn means that their emotions tend toward darkness: frustration, bitterness, loneliness, resentment, anger, and melancholy.

Gold masks cover void faces. When a human dies on Theros, a funerary mask of dark clay is customary, used to "frame" the identity of the deceased for Athreos. So when a mortal destroys his or her identity to leave the Underworld, that mortal must fashion a mask to stand in for it. Gold is the most common material in Erebos's realm, so it has become customary for the Returned to symbolically replace their funerary masks (and by proxy their identities) with beautifully crafted gold masks that cover their changed faces and function as surrogate, albeit flimsy, identities.



Concept Art by Peter Mohrbacher

"Coins" of dark clay. Because gold is commonplace in the Underworld, the Returned don't value it (except their own masks) and instead use special clay pieces called ostraka as a kind of currency or barter tool. Each ostrakon is a shard from a dark clay funerary mask. These pieces of clay have great significance to the Returned for obvious reasons, and they are used as mementos by inhabitants of the necropolis of Asphodel, as trophies by those of Odunos, and as ornamentation and currency by all of their kind.



Art by Robbie Trevino

Necropolises

The Returned refer to their two small city-states as necropolises mostly without irony—they are occupied by the dead, after all. Smaller, more isolated settlements exist, and some of the Returned eschew civilization altogether, occupying caves or simply wandering. The two necropolises, roughly equal in size, are called Asphodel and Odunos. Each has a kind of overarching characteristic: Asphodel's is despondence; Odunos's is anger.

Asphodel. The polis of Asphodel, situated in a sprawling, inland, coastal marsh, is home to those Returned who have a deep nostalgia for things they can no longer remember. It is, for the most part, a dull place, although it maintains a guard and an order of mages for defense. Its citizens seek to be left alone, venturing out only when seized by fugues of emotion, or when resources are needed or desired (often for unrecalled reasons). The main sources of conflict in Asphodel are occasional raids on

the polis by living beings who have become convinced by their leaders or their gods that the Returned are an abomination to be eliminated. Asphodel is symbolically aligned with Erebus in that its residents accept their fate.

Odunos. This polis stands in contrast to Asphodel. Its citizens tend toward a combination of greedy, violent, and resentful. These Returned have come to envy and/or despise the living and are driven by a desire to deprive them of the joys of life. Odunos raiders strike at any humanoids nearby-leonin, minotaurs, and the humans of Akros and environs. Their raids are small but effective, and almost always nocturnal. Whereas Asphodel's citizens pointlessly amass wealth, Odunos seeks to destroy the wealth of the living (both literal, such as gold, and figurative, such as food, children, and comfort). The Returned of Odunos desire little for themselves beyond water.



Concept Art by Peter Mohrbacher

Notable Figures and Objects



Art by Volkan Baga

Tymaret of Odunos. Known by humans as the Murderer King, Tymaret acts as the *de facto* leader of Odunos, organizing raids and commanding the best warriors.

Minotaurs



Art by Kev Walker

Minotaurs are the barbaric, cave-dwelling raiders of Theros, barely sentient and certainly not sapient. Although they are among Theros's races, for all intents and purposes they are monsters, seeking only mayhem and meat, killing each other when they're not killing humanoids of other races. They have no high objective, no culture to speak of, and only the most rudimentary language. Most are found in the high mountains of Phoberos or Akros. Some have been known to frequent swamps, which has turned their hide and hair black with peat.



Art by Matt Stewart

Bone-strewn caves. Minotaurs will squat in any cave, cavern, or shaft they deem large enough and safe enough. Their lairs are littered with refuse, dung, and the bones of a wide variety of animals and other races, but especially with the bones from their favorite meat: human.



Art by Wayne Reynolds

Only the mighty can lead. Only the mightiest and most ferocious of minotaurs can force the herd into compliance. Fights between minotaur alphas can be heard for miles and almost certainly end in a gory death. The victor claims dominance and fealty.



Art by Phill Simmer

Satyrs



Art by Christopher Moeller

The satyrs of Theros are well-loved for their good spirits, their love of revels, and their boisterous, gregarious personalities. Those who feel differently know to keep their opinions to themselves. And so their fun-loving reputation expands, and the darker aspects of their nature are kept quiet-except in the minds of the humans tricked into becoming their caretakers.

Skola Valley

This verdant, highly enchanted valley dotted with copses of trees lies in Theros's chaparral. The satyrs subsist on the magic of the valley to the point that their lives resemble one long party. There are no permanent settlements, and the music of pipes can be heard from dawn until dusk.



Art by Wesley Burt

Worldview

With all their basic needs provided for, the satyrs are free to pursue pleasure as the only goal in life. There are few lasting bonds between satyrs, all of whom dwell in a state of abject hedonism. They are generous when it suits their ambitions; they are cruel when those ambitions are thwarted. Since everyone ends up in the same Underworld, they believe honor and righteousness are useless endeavors. "Taste the world," say the satyrs, "before Erebos rips your tongue out."



Art by Tyler Jacobson

Cult of Horns. Frequently humans come to Skola in search of endless pleasure without consequences. When they first arrive, they are courted by the satyrs. They are told they will learn the mysteries of Nyx. They enjoy days of revelries, music, and ecstatic dance-all without a care in the world. Inevitably, the hospitality gives way to something more sinister, and these unsuspecting humans find themselves conscripted into service of the satyrs.

The satyr sybils decide when these newcomers are ready for full initiation rites. Many humans undertake the rites, never knowing the joke is on them, and are awarded a crown made of broken horns-a symbol of mockery. Once given the crown, they are known as Stubs. They are assigned menial, humiliating tasks. Enchantment magic keeps them in the thrall of the satyrs until, inevitably, the satyrs tire. Then the Stubs are deserted in the wild chaparral, where they awake hours later, alone, dazed, and

ashamed. Out of embarrassment, Stubs seldom tell the true story of their time with the satyrs.

Many perpetuate the myth of the joy and excitement of their time in Skola, encouraging the younger generation to "sow their wild oats" among the satyrs.

Revelries

The dual nature of the satyrs is evident in the types of revelries they hold.



Art by Kev Walker

Rollick Night. Satyrs host festivals for humans in the poleis several times a year. These are splendid affairs with good food, drink, and entertainment. The satyrs are jovial and welcoming, and while the streets are trashed the next morning, rarely do things get out of control. These Rollick Nights are the foundation

of the satyrs' renown and the places where they "recruit" the most humans for the Cult of Horns.



Art by Anthony Palumbo

Bakkeia. These are hardcore celebrations of ritual madness that happen only in the Skola Valley. They often begin pleasantly enough but descend into defilement, sacrifice, and violence done by those who hold the power in the valley. Caves under the valley heated by geothermal gases are the sites of some of the most depraved rituals.

Centaurs

Theran centaurs are humanity's most consistent allies and trade partners, but their populations are not monolithic. Over countless centuries, the centaurs of Theros slowly divided into two distinct bands, the Lagonna and the Pheres. Whereas the Lagonna are traders who sometimes settle an area, the Pheres are nomads and raiders.

Lagonna Band

The Lagonna travel in small merchant family bands called guri (singular "guros"). They most commonly trade with Meletis, which provides the biggest market for their wares, but they also do business with Setessa.



Art by Min Yum

Lagonna Roles

Elder. The head of each guros is typically its eldest member. The family head has the final say on all clan-related decisions.

Barterer. Each guros has a barterer who serves as liaison between the guros and its trade clients. Barterers are, by necessity, more diplomatic and more knowledgeable of other cultures than the average centaur.

Omener. The omener reads messages from the gods for the guros. These messages can be from an eagle flying overhead, a lightning-struck tree, a toad crushed on the roadway, and the like. The omener has knowledge of all of these "omen signs" as well as which god may have sent them.

Courser. Coursers explore new trade territory for the guros. They may not be with the guros for long stretches, but their excellent tracking skills always enable them to find their group again in short order.

Koletra. Every guros tries to travel with at least one of the Koletra-burly, well-trained warriors of the Lagonna Band. Not every guros has Koletra of its own, and guri share their best warriors among each other as a sign of goodwill and a way to forge bonds.

Heptaristi Once per year, a massive Lagonna herd is gathered and all guri attend. The Lagonna trade heavily among their own during this summit, but the highlight of the event is the choosing of the Heptaristi, the seven leaders. Seven guros elders are chosen to form the Heptaristi and to make all of the most important decisions for the band. The Lagonna treat this as if it was a democratic affair, but in truth, most seats are purchased through trade agreements with other clan leaders.

Lagonna Notable Figures

Bromos. Bromos is a hefty male centaur known for his booming voice and hard-nosed haggling. He is the elder of the Surm guros, one of the oldest Lagonna guri. He has served on the Heptaristi four times.



Art by Trevor Claxton

Oka. Oka is a lithe female centaur who is widely held to be the best courser of any guros. She was married into and has served the Maiand guros for years, and has remained with them even though her mate died several years ago. Oka is also known for her skills with a shortbow.

Pheres Band

The Pheres roam the wild lands between Setessa and Akros. Their family ties are looser than those of the Lagonna Band, and on some occasions they form large raid hordes to secure resources and new hunting grounds. They are slightly larger than the Lagonna, and they are also quite a bit more savage. Pheres names are often descriptions of a physical feature or the circumstances of an individual's birth.



Art by [Kev Walker](#)

Pheres Roles

Charger. Unlike the Lagonna, who are ruled by their elders, the Pheres are led by their strongest and most dominant. Each small raiding herd follows a charger, and leadership tends to be stable until the charger ages to the point where he or she can't lead effectively anymore.

Caller. Pheres "callers" are shamans and summoners with the ability to call animals to aid the band and to enchant their allies with animal energies. A caller can be identified by the ornately carved horn he or she carries, called an oulokeros.

Tromper. Centaur legends say that when the gods first fashioned humans from the red mud of the eldest river, it was Pheres trompers who taught them how to corner and kill prey. Trompers are the feared raiders and warriors of the Pheres Band.



Art by Steve Prescott

Pheres Notable Figures

Great-Hoof. Great-Hoof is the charger of one of the largest Pheres raiding bands. He is large, muscular, and highly skilled as a tactician. It's rumored that he once broke the back of a minotaur with one kick.

Wide-Eyes. Wide-Eyes is among the youngest of Pheres callers, and her skills are already renowned. She tends to be quite reclusive unless the band needs her aid. Her most stalwart companion is a small squirrel she calls Glokhis.

Smoke-Born. Smoke-Born is a middle-aged healer who serves several raiding bands. Her birth took place as her home village, Kithara, was burned to the ground by Akroan warriors. Smoke-Born has many small wooden totems braided into her mangy hair, and although her appearance can be disconcerting, her healing skills are unmatched.

Nymphs

Nymphs are divinely created creatures that inhabit special places, infusing them with the magic of Nyx. Most are benevolent and associated with healing or other life-giving magic, but dark nymphs dwell near the entrances to the Underworld and in places of great sorrow as well. Nymphs were intentionally created by the gods and can act as companions, messengers, guardians, or scouts.

Nymphs tend to be mysterious, shy creatures who spend most of their lives around a single location. Although they are corporeal, they "inhabit" aspects of the natural world, such as trees, lakes, or caves. They often live in groups. They have no need for sustenance or shelter; they subsist on the magic of Nyx. They rarely interact with humans. They do not grow old or suffer from illness, but they can be killed.

Alseid. These white-aligned nymphs inhabit meadows. They protect flocks and are in closer proximity to human civilization than any of the other nymphs.



Art by Todd Lockwood

Naiad. Blue-aligned nymphs can be found anywhere there is water. They are common in the streams and grottos of the Nistos Forest. Naiad also make their home on isolated beaches and shorelines, although they prefer areas with more cover.



Art by David Palumbo

Lampad. These rare, black-aligned nymphs are said to help Athreos in guiding the dead to the Underworld. They sometimes bear torches that burn violet.



Art by Volkan Baga

Oread. The most aggressive and dangerous nymphs, these red-aligned creatures dwell in remote mountain crevasses and near volcanoes. Purphoros is fond of their company, and these nymphs also take part in satyr bakkeia-but only the very wildest ones.



Art by Todd Lockwood

Dryad. Nylea has created many green-aligned nymphs, and her followers can be found throughout the Nistos and Skola regions.



Art by Volkan Baga

Giants



Art by Lars Grant-West

Theran giants are an ancient race of towering humanoids born from the land itself. They get their strength from the ancient rocks of the hills, the roots of old-growth trees, the surging waters of great rivers, and even the darkness of echoing caverns.

Eidolons



Art by Min Yum

When a dead person escapes the Underworld, they lose their identity and become one of the faceless Returned. But in this process of severing the physical body from the "soul," an eidolon is also created. An eidolon is the spectral embodiment of the lost identity, but without its body, it has no agency. Unlike the Returned, it has no sense of what it lost. The Returned and its severed eidolon are never reunited, nor are they aware of one another's existence.

While some eidolons forever wander, others linger in a certain place. This "haunt" isn't chosen because of a connection to its former life. More often, it's near a place where a nymph lives. It's believed that eidolons are instinctually drawn to nymphs' magic, like a cub is drawn to the warmth of its mother. The nymphs are usually sympathetic to these creatures.

Griffins



Art by Phill Simmer

Majestic but fearsome creatures with the bodies of lions and the wings and heads of eagles, griffins are reclusive creatures that live along the borders of Phoberos. They hunt for food in the chaparral, and their keen eyes sense the slightest movement in the scrubland. Wild griffins are ferocious and hunt small humans, killing them with a single blow and carrying them off into their treetop aeries to devour them. Several Meletis hoplites have managed to tame griffins as mounts over the years.

Archons



Celestial Archon | Art by Matt Stewart

Archons are a relic of Theros's past, a race of mysterious conquerors who soar on the backs of giant winged bulls. Archons once ruled as overlords of huge expanses of Theros, using armies of other races to triumph over their lands. Archons saw themselves as champions of a strict, merciless justice, and ruled with an iron fist. But the age of the archons came to an end. As the archon overlords were toppled one by one, their holdings became the poleis. Individual archons still roam the world, eager to right what they see as the great wrongs perpetrated in this age of Theros.

Sirens



Art by Daarken

Sirens are a race of bird-winged humanoids whose enchanting songs and natural illusion magic are the subject of legend. Sirens feed on fish and sea birds primarily; their songs help lure creatures toward them. But sirens feed on humanoid flesh just as happily. The legendary beauty of their song often lures passing sailors, who risk unsafe tides and currents to hear their melodies. Many shipwrecks and drownings are attributed to sirens' songs.

Chimeras



Art by Dan Scott

These monsters are the product of overambitious magecraft-the fusing of essences from three, four, or even five creatures to create a new and dangerous one.

Most of these living amalgams fly, and some breathe fire or possess a deadly gaze or a poisonous bite or sting. Some believe they are the product of Keranos's folly; that he "inspired" a mage with lightning, leaving the mage's mind damaged but impassioned in one stroke. Others believe the secrets to the creation of chimeras come from a long-forgotten polis where magic was wielded too recklessly.

Sphinxes



Art by Steve Prescott

Sphinxes are long-lived Theran monsters of dizzying intellect. Sphinxes do not set out to be enigmatic; their abstract thoughts only seem riddle-like to mortal minds.

Krakens



Shipbreaker Kraken | Art by Jack Wang

Krakens are fearsome, destructive gargantuans of the sea and the most terrifying entities of Theran depths. The arrival of a single determined kraken can spell the end of an entire polis, and even casual actions by a kraken can wipe out fleets of ships or decimate fishing grounds.

Krakens' destructive power comes not only from their immense size, but also because they seem able to breathe air and can crawl on land, meaning they can create swaths of destruction along the coasts or even deeper inland.

Catoblepases



Art by Christopher Burdett

A foul, ox-like creature with deadly, toxic breath, the catoblepas is thought to be the result of a curse by the gods. A herder bragged that his livestock was the finest in all of Theros because it had been created by Heliod and Nylea themselves. He grew rich from the lie, and the gods grew angry at the injustice. Heliod convinced Mogis to place a curse on the cattle, transforming them into poisonous, fetid creatures.

Harpies



Art by Kev Walker

A harpy is a vicious creature with the head of a woman and the wings and legs of a vulture. Harpies are shrieking buzzards of the badlands and the forests that border them, intent on robbing, harassing, and even killing anyone who enters their territory. They tend to avoid attacking adult humans, preferring to injure them and take their belongings. Their aeries are filled with stolen objects they have no use for.

Gorgons



Art by Chris Rahn

It is not known how many gorgons exist. On occasion, mortals attempt to capture a gorgon in order to force her to tell the secret of immortality. These mortals usually end up as statues, petrified by the gorgon's gaze; only the favor of the gods can turn stone back to flesh. Gorgons take delight in dispensing valuable secrets at the cost of deadly risk, and more than one medicinal breakthrough has come from someone surviving a gorgon's test.

Demons



Art by Slawomir Maniak

Some souls in the Underworld come to despise their afterlives, growing more and more hateful over time. The most malicious, the ones whose hate reaches the level of true evil, become demons. The transformation occurs quickly, in an incredibly painful vortex of black-mana energy. Once it is complete, the demon can, with great effort and risk, fly back over the Rivers That Ring the World and return to the realm of mortals. Demons that survive the journey use their "second lives" in a variety of ways. Some take up residence in remote places, causing animals to flee the area and plants to blacken and die. Others wander, finding opportunities to torment the living along the way.

Cerberus



Art by Svetlin Velinov

These fearsome creatures roam the mortal-realm side of the Rivers That Ring the World. Each cerberus is at least four feet tall at the shoulder and has two or three heads. The cerberus have paws like half-molten stone, and they leave seared, smoking tracks as they walk. As a result, the land that borders the first of the Rivers That Ring the World is a blackened, smoldering wasteland that's several hundred meters wide. The nature and origins of the cerberus are unknown. They are not creations of the gods, and they are feared by the living and the dead alike. Because of their boundless hunger for meat, especially that of humanoids, cerberus can be lured away from the riverbank, then set loose on an area.

Cyclopes



Art by Raymond Swanland

Solitary, belligerent, and relatively stupid, the cyclopes are territorial and feared for their unrelenting aggression and inability to feel pain. Once a cyclops has its eye on you or your village, there's no stopping it. It takes a truly heroic effort to take one down-or a small army of battle-hardened hoplites.

Manticores



Concept Art by Steve Prescott

These rare creatures live in the far reaches of Theros, beyond leonin lands. A manticore has the body of a lion, a human-like head with many rows of teeth, and a deadly tail. Akroans say each manticore is the reincarnated spirit of a once-great warrior, part of an army slaughtered defending its homeland from archons. The warriors were so full of life and valor that the gods intervened and transformed them into manticores.

Phoenixes



Concept Art by Richard Whitters

Phoenixes make their nests within the craters of volcanoes and are therefore associated with Purphoros. A phoenix lays just one egg during its centuries-long life, at the end of which it plunges itself into the volcano near which it lives. On that day, the egg hatches and a new phoenix is born.

Dragons



Art by Slawomir Maniak

On Theros, dragons range from about the size of a monitor lizard to the size of a small kraken. They rule the skies above the highest mountains of Theros, preying on rocs, griffins, and large animals such as boar. The Akroans revere the majesty of the large dragons and fashion their helm crests to resemble a dragon's dorsal crest.

Basilisks



Art by Wayne Reynolds

Reptilian monsters with a venomous bite and a deadly gaze, basilisks are an unpredictable threat for travelers through remote wilds. They range from a few feet to almost twenty feet long and can move with startling stealth and speed. Despite the dangers in acquiring it, there is a market for basilisk blood. Healers use diluted blood in potions and oracles use it in prophecy rituals. It's said that Pharika hid many secrets in basilisk blood, although most die trying to learn them.

Hydras



Art by Ryan Pancoast

What krakens are to the sea and dragons are to the sky, hydras are to the land of Theros. These towering, many-headed monsters have rapid regenerative properties and acidic blood. They can withstand countless attacks, and some even grow stronger if wounded but not killed.

Hydras can spend years dormant, but they continue to grow during this time. Great thickets grow over the largest sleeping hydras, hiding them from wanderers. When they awaken, they go on rampages that destroy great swaths of land.